

Chapter 15 — Puruṣottama Yoga

పురుషోత్తమయోగః : పురుషోత్తమయోగము

"The Yoga of the Supreme Person" · 20 verses · The inverted cosmic tree & the highest reality

Chapter 15 is short, mysterious, and breathtaking. It opens with one of the most enigmatic images in the Gītā: the **inverted aśvattha (peepal) tree** — roots in the heavens, branches reaching down into the world. This is saṁsāra — the cycle of life, fed by desire. Cut its root with the axe of detachment, says Kṛṣṇa.

The chapter then reveals the soul's true nature (*mamaivāṁśo* — "a fragment of My own self"), declares the Lord as the **inner light of memory, knowledge, and discernment**, and culminates in the term that gives the chapter its name: **Puruṣottama** — the Supreme Person, beyond both the perishable and the imperishable.

Essential verses of Chapter 15

BG 15.1 The inverted aśvattha tree — saṁsāra

ऊर्ध्वमूलमधःशाखमश्वत्थं प्राहुरव्ययम् ।

छन्दांसि यस्य पर्णानि यस्तं वेद स वेदवित् ॥ १५.१ ॥

ఊర్ధ్వమూలమధఃశాఖమశ్వత్థం ప్రాహురవ్యయమ్ ।

ఛందాంసి యస్య పర్ణాని యస్తం వేద స వేదవిత్ ॥ ౧౫.౧ ॥

ūrdhva-mūlam adhaḥ-śākhām aśvattham prāhur avyayam |

chandāṁsi yasy parṇāni yas taṁ veda sa veda-vit ||

"They speak of an indestructible aśvattha tree —
with roots above and branches below,
whose leaves are the Vedic hymns.
One who knows this tree is a knower of the Veda."

BG 15.7 The soul is an eternal fragment of the Divine

ममैवांशो जीवलोके जीवभूतः सनातनः ।

मनःषष्ठानीन्द्रियाणि प्रकृतिस्थानि कर्षति ॥ १५.७ ॥

మమైవాంశో జీవలోకే జీవభూతః సనాతనః ।

మనఃషష్ఠానీంద్రియాణి ప్రకృతిస్థాని కర్షతి ॥ ౧౫.౭ ॥

mamaivāṁśo jīva-loke jīva-bhūtaḥ sanātanaḥ |

manaḥ-ṣaṣṭhānīndriyāṇi prakṛti-sthāni karṣati ||

"An eternal fragment of My own Self,
having become the individual soul in this world of life,
draws to itself the six senses (with the mind), which abide in nature."

Word-by-Word — 15.7 (mamaivāṁśo)

IAST	ममैवांशो	मम एव अंशः	PRONUNCIATION	MEANING
<i>mama eva aṁśaḥ</i>	मम एव अंशः	మమ ఏవ అంశః	MA-ma E-va AN-shah	My very own fragment / part
<i>jīva-loke</i>	जीवलोके	జీవలోకే	JEE-va-LO-ke	in the world of living beings
<i>jīva-bhūtaḥ</i>	जीवभूतः	జీవభూతః	JEE-va-BHOO-tah	having become the individual soul
<i>sanātanaḥ</i>	सनातनः	సనాతనః	sa-NAA-ta-nah	eternal, primeval
<i>manaḥ-ṣaṣṭhāni</i>	मनःषष्ठानि	మనఃషష్ఠాని	MA-nah-SHASH-thaa-ni	with the mind as the sixth

IAST	संस्कृत	ఇంగ్లీషు	PRONUNCIATION	MEANING
<i>indriyāṇi</i>	इन्द्रियाणि	అంద్రియాణి	in-dri-YAA-ni	the senses
<i>prakṛti-sthāni</i>	प्रकृतिस्थानि	ప్రకృతిస్థాని	pra-KRI-ti-STHAA-ni	abiding in nature
<i>karṣati</i>	कर्षति	కర్షతి	KAR-sha-ti	draws to itself, attracts

BG 15.15 *I am seated in the hearts of all — source of memory, knowledge, forgetfulness*

सर्वस्य चाहं हृदि सन्निविष्टो
 मत्तः स्मृतिर्ज्ञानमपोहनं च ।
 वेदैश्च सर्वैरहमेव वेद्यो
 वेदान्तकृद्वेदविदेव चाहम् ॥ १५.१५ ॥

*sarvasya cāham hṛdi sanniviṣṭo
 mattaḥ smṛtir jñānam apohanam ca |
 vedaiś ca sarvair aham eva vedyo
 vedānta-kṛd veda-vid eva cāham ||*

"I am seated in the hearts of all.
 From Me come memory, knowledge, and forgetfulness.
 By all the Vedas I alone am to be known —
 I am the maker of Vedānta and the knower of the Vedas."

BG 15.20 *Closing — one who knows this is wise and his task is complete*

इति गुह्यतमं शास्त्रमिदमुक्तं मयानघ ।
 एतद्बुद्ध्वा बुद्धिमान्स्यात्कृतकृत्यश्च भारत ॥ १५.२० ॥

*iti guhyatamaṁ śāstram idam uktaṁ mayānagha |
 etad buddhvā buddhimān syāt kṛta-kṛtyaś ca bhārata ||*

"Thus this most secret teaching has been declared by Me, O sinless one.
 Knowing this, one becomes wise — and one's task in life is complete, O Bhārata."

□ Essential take-away of Chapter 15

You are not what you think you are.

You are not the body. You are not even the individual person. You are **an eternal fragment of the Divine itself** (*mamaivāṁśo*) — somehow caught up in a vast inverted tree of desires and senses.

The work is to remember who you are and cut the cord. The Lord, says Kṛṣṇa, is the inner light by which all knowledge happens — including this very recognition.

"In every act of remembering, it is the Divine remembering through you."